STUDY AID · MATTHEW 26:3-16 · EPISODE 50 (#53 OF 58 IN THE PLAYLIST)

Anointed *for Burial*

Look with God's eyes

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 26:3-16 in the LSB | 25:51 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: They Were Closest to Jesus — And Still Missed What God Was Doing. Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO | BACKGROUND (ADDED) | DEBATED | LSB TEXT | ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 26:3-16. The chief priests and elders meet in the court of Caiaphas and plot to seize Jesus by stealth, but not during the festival. In Bethany, at the home of Simon the leper, a woman pours an alabaster jar of very costly perfume on Jesus' head. The disciples are indignant: 'Why this waste?' Jesus defends her: she has prepared Him for burial, and she will be remembered wherever the gospel is proclaimed. Then Judas goes to the chief priests, and they weigh out thirty pieces of silver.
- Jesus is surrounded by adversaries: the leaders plotting (26:3-5), His own disciples opposing what He affirms (26:6-9), and Judas plotting with the chief priests (26:14-16). John identifies the woman as Mary of Bethany and says Judas objected (John 12:3-5).
- Messiah means anointed one. Kings (Saul, David, Solomon, Joash, Jehu) and priests were anointed, and so were the tabernacle and its furnishings (Exodus 30:22-30). Oil also meant joy: 'the oil of joy' (Psalm 45:7) and 'the oil of rejoicing instead of mourning' (Isaiah 61:3). The disciples should have recognized the symbolism.
- Thirty pieces of silver was the price of a slave gored by an ox (Exodus 21:32) and the insulting wage Israel paid the prophet in Zechariah 11:12-13, which he threw 'to the potter in the house of Yahweh.' Judas will throw the silver into the sanctuary, and it will buy the Potter's Field

> *"Lacking mercy leads to condemning what is not understood and becoming blind to the activity of God."*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"The disciples should have recognized this symbolic act for what it was."*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

(27:3-10). The plot echoes Psalm 31:13: 'They schemed to take my life.'

- The lesson: lacking mercy leads to condemning what is not understood and becoming blind to the activity of God. Like the Pharisees in Matthew 12:7, the disciples condemned the innocent. They should have let Jesus' reaction guide theirs.

Watch how Jesus responds

When something in a passage puzzles you, look first at how Jesus reacts to it, and let His response shape yours.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB. This is Episode 50 of the Matthew study (playlist item 53).

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 26:3-16 and turns to Mark 14, John 12, Psalms 31 and 45, Isaiah 61, Exodus 21 and 30, Zechariah 11, Matthew 12 and 27 and 2 Corinthians 2. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 26:3-16
Read in full: the plot, the anointing and Judas.

Mark 14:3-9
Mark's account: 'they were scolding her.'

John 12:1-8
John names Mary and Judas's objection.

Psalm 31:5
Quoted by Jesus on the cross (Luke 23:46).

Psalm 31:13
They schemed to take my life.

Psalm 45:7
The oil of joy above Your companions.

Isaiah 61:1-3
Anointed to bring good news; the oil of rejoicing.

Exodus 30:22-30
The holy anointing oil.

Exodus 21:32
Thirty shekels of silver for a slave.

Zechariah 11:12-13
Thirty shekels thrown to the potter.

Matthew 27:3-10
Judas returns the silver; the Potter's Field.

Matthew 12:1-8
'I desire compassion, and not a sacrifice.'

2 Corinthians 2:14-16
The aroma of Christ.

Key verses in the LSB

"For when she poured this perfume on My body, she did it to prepare Me for burial."
Matthew 26:12 (LSB)

"You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness; / Therefore God, Your God, has anointed You / With the oil of joy above Your companions."
Psalm 45:7 (LSB)

"For we are a fragrance of Christ to God among those who are being saved and among those who are perishing;"
2 Corinthians 2:15 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The plot

The leaders scheme in the court of Caiaphas.



MATTHEW 26:3-5

Plotting in the court of Caiaphas

MATTHEW 26:3-5 (LSB)

BY STEALTH

"Then the chief priests and the elders of the people were gathered together in the court of the high priest, named Caiaphas; and they plotted together to seize Jesus by stealth and kill Him. But they were saying, "Not during the festival, lest a riot occur among the people.""

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus is surrounded by adversaries: the leaders plot His murder, His disciples oppose what He affirms, and one of them plots to betray Him.

◆ Factbook: Sanhedrin ◆ Factbook: Passover



PSALM 31:5, 13

They schemed to take my life

DAVID · PSALM 31:13
"For I have heard the bad report of many, / Terror is on every side; / While they took counsel together against me, / They schemed to take my life."

DAVID · PSALM 31:5
"Into Your hand I commit my spirit; / You have ransomed me, O Yahweh, God of truth."

FROM THE VIDEO David takes refuge in the Lord while surrounded by enemies. Jesus quotes verse 5 with His last breath (Luke 23:46), and the leaders' plotting matches verse 13. Luke 23:46

◆ Factbook: Book of Psalms ◆ Factbook: David

> *“They heard Jesus speak of his death, but they had no category for a Messiah whose kingship would come through atoning suffering.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The anointing at Bethany

Waste, kingship, priesthood and the oil of joy.

MATTHEW 26:6-9

'Why this waste?'

MATTHEW 26:7-9 (LSB)

INDIGNANT

“a woman came to Him with an alabaster jar of very costly perfume, and she poured it on His head as He reclined at the table. But when the disciples saw this, they were indignant, saying, “Why this waste? For this perfume might have been sold for a high price and the money given to the poor.””

FROM THE VIDEO John names the woman as Mary of Bethany, Martha's sister, and says Judas objected (John 12:3-5). In Matthew the objection spreads to the rest of the disciples; Mark says 'they were scolding her' (Mark 14:5). John 12:3-5 Mark 14:5

FROM THE VIDEO The disciples cared more about what the oil could have bought than what it was accomplishing.

◆ Factbook: Leprosy ◆ Factbook: Bethany (Mount of Olives) ◆ Factbook: Judas Iscariot

EXODUS 30:22-30; PSALM 45:7

Anointed like a king and priest

MOSES · EXODUS 30:30

“And you shall anoint Aaron and his sons, and you shall set them apart as holy, that they may minister as priests to Me.”

THE PSALMIST · PSALM 45:7

“You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness; / Therefore God, Your God, has anointed You / With the oil of joy above Your companions.”

FROM THE VIDEO Messiah means anointed one. Saul, David, Solomon, Joash and Jehu were anointed as kings (1 Samuel 16; 2 Samuel 2; 1 Kings 1; 2 Kings 9), and the holy anointing oil set apart the tent of meeting, the ark, the lampstand, the altars and the priests.

1 Samuel 16:13 1 Kings 1:39 2 Kings 9:6

FROM THE VIDEO The video compares it to someone standing in front of the US Capitol and reciting the presidential oath of office.

◆ Factbook: Messiah ◆ Factbook: Aaron ◆ Factbook: Priest ◆ Factbook: Tabernacle

ISAIAH 61:1-3; MATTHEW 26:10-13

The oil of rejoicing

😊 ISAIAH 61:3 (LSB)

ISAIAH 61

“To grant those who mourn in Zion, / Giving them a headdress instead of ashes, / The oil of rejoicing instead of mourning, / The mantle of praise instead of a spirit of fainting. / So they will be called oaks of righteousness, / The planting of Yahweh, that He may show forth His beautiful glory.”

FROM THE VIDEO Whether or not she grasped all its depth, her act resonates with Isaiah 61: joy, anointing and messianic fulfillment. It says Jesus is king, priest, and about to be buried.

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus was right: 'what this woman has done will also be spoken of in memory of her' (26:13). Paul uses the same fragrance imagery: 'we are a fragrance of Christ to God' (2 Corinthians 2:15). Matthew 26:13 2 Corinthians 2:14-16

◆ Factbook: Isaiah ◆ Factbook: Gospel ◆ Factbook: Paul



She poured it on His head

James Tissot, The Ointment of the Magdalene, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *“The disciples should have recognized this symbolic act for what it was.*
>
> From the video

05 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

Thirty pieces of silver

The price of a slave, Zechariah's wage, and the lesson of mercy.

MATTHEW 26:14-16; EXODUS 21:32

The price of a slave

MATTHEW · MATTHEW 26:15

THE LAW · EXODUS 21:32

"and said, "What are you willing to give me to deliver Him to you?" And they weighed out thirty pieces of silver to him."

"If the ox gores a male or female slave, the owner shall give his or her master thirty shekels of silver, and the ox shall be stoned."

FROM THE VIDEO Thirty pieces of silver was a low amount that represented the value of a slave's life. The chief priests may be showing they see Jesus as no more than a lowly slave, or as compensation for property damage.

FROM THE VIDEO How did Judas know which group to go to? We're not told.

◆ Factbook: Judas Iscariot



ZECHARIAH 11:12-13; MATTHEW 27:3-10

Thrown to the potter

ZECHARIAH · ZECHARIAH 11:13

"Then Yahweh said to me, "Throw it to the potter, that valuable price at which I was valued by them." So I took the thirty shekels of silver and threw them to the potter in the house of Yahweh."

MATTHEW · MATTHEW 27:5

"And he threw the pieces of silver into the sanctuary and departed; and he went away and hanged himself."

FROM THE VIDEO The people sarcastically valued the prophet at a slave's price; God called them the unworthy ones. Judas will throw the silver into the sanctuary, and it will buy the Potter's Field (27:7). Matthew 27:7

BACKGROUND Matthew 27:9 credits the fulfillment to 'Jeremiah the prophet'; the wording draws on Zechariah 11:12-13 with echoes of Jeremiah 18-19 and 32.

◆ Factbook: Zechariah (father of John the Baptist) ◆ Factbook: Jeremiah (prophet) ◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)



MATTHEW 12:1-8

Becoming like the Pharisees

MATTHEW 12:7 (LSB)

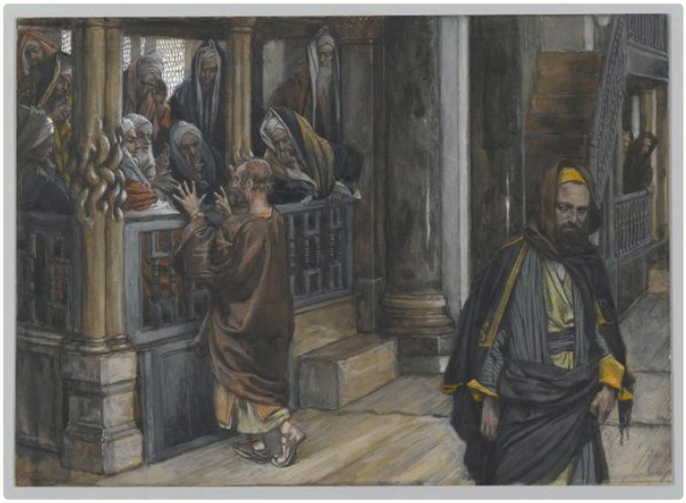
MERCY

"But if you had known what this means, 'I desire compassion, and not a sacrifice,' you would not have condemned the innocent."

FROM THE VIDEO When the hungry disciples plucked grain on the Sabbath, the Pharisees condemned them. Now the disciples condemn the woman: they have not learned the lesson.

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus neither stops nor scolds her. That should have been their clue; if they had questions, they could have asked Him privately later.

◆ Factbook: Mercy ◆ Factbook: Pharisees ◆ Factbook: Sabbath



What are you willing to give me?

James Tissot, Judas Goes to Find the Jews, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *They should have let Jesus reaction guide their response.*
>
> From the video

06

Who's who in 26:3-16

What the video says, then a short background note.

Caiaphas

VIDEO The high priest in whose court the leaders plot.

BACKGROUND High priest c. AD 18-36, son-in-law of Annas (John 18:13).

Matthew 26:3 | John 11:49-53 | ◆ Caiaphas

The woman (Mary of Bethany)

VIDEO Anoints Jesus' head; John names her Mary, Martha's sister.

BACKGROUND In John she anoints His feet and wipes them with her hair (John 12:3).

John 12:3 | ◆ Bethany (Mount of Olives) | ◆ Mary of Bethany | ◆ Woman anoints Jesus at Bethany

Simon the leper

VIDEO Host of the meal in Bethany.

BACKGROUND Otherwise unknown; perhaps healed by Jesus.

Matthew 26:6 | ◆ Leprosy | ◆ Simon the leper

Judas Iscariot

VIDEO Goes to the chief priests for thirty pieces of silver.

BACKGROUND John calls him a thief who kept the money box (John 12:6).

Matthew 26:14-16 | John 12:6 | ◆ Judas Iscariot

Zechariah the prophet

VIDEO Valued at a slave's price; throws the silver to the potter.

BACKGROUND Prophet after the exile, c. 520 BC.

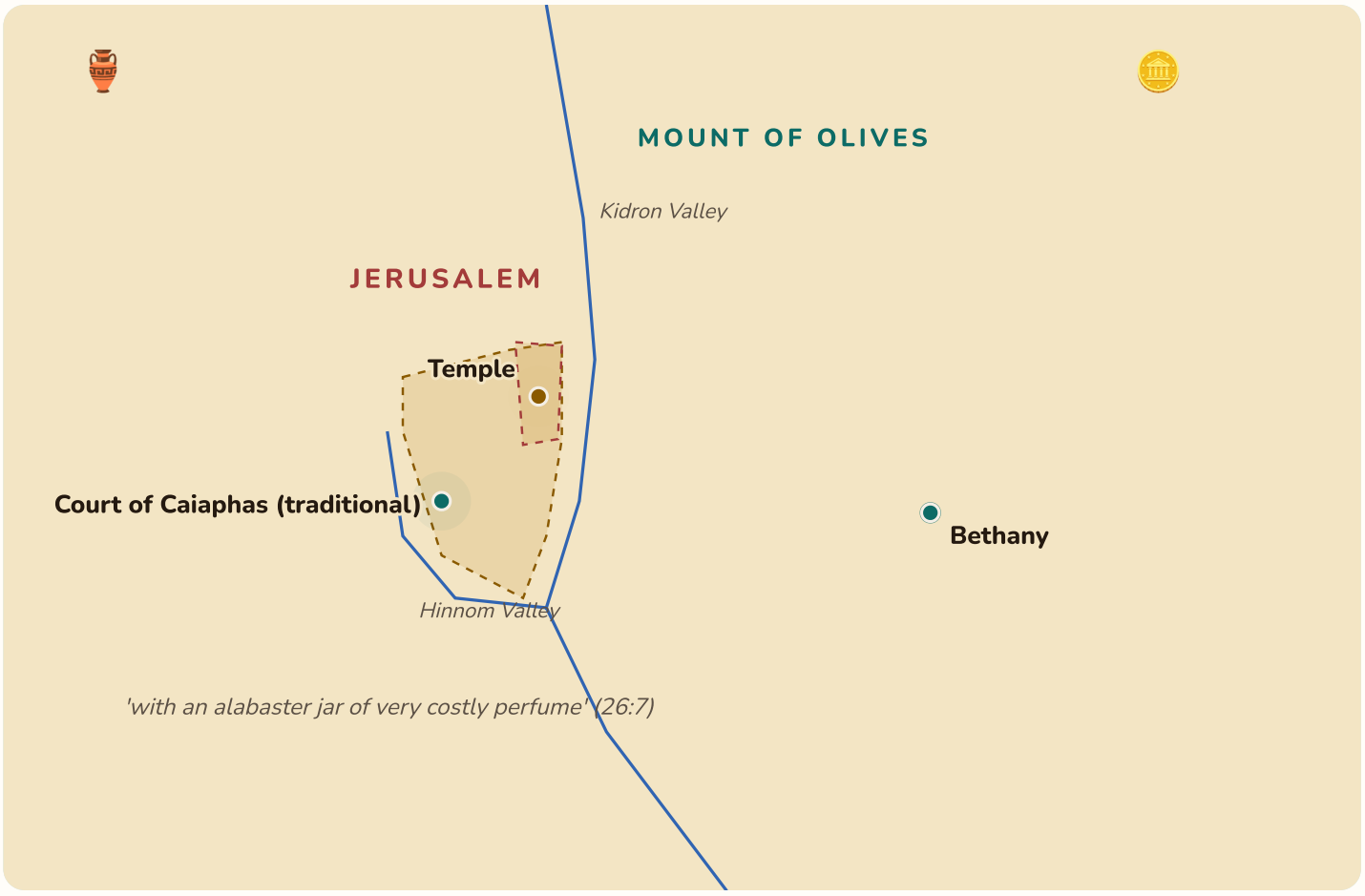
Zechariah 11:12-13

◆ Zechariah (father of John the Baptist)

07 · BACKGROUND

Bethany and Jerusalem

The pin outlined in the video's color is a place the video points to. Gold pins are background.



● Named in the video ● Background

Schematic: drawn for this study from known sites. Walls (gold dashes) and the temple platform (coral dashes) are approximate for the first century. Traditional sites are marked as traditional.

Bethany VIDEO

The home of Simon the leper, where Jesus was anointed (26:6).

◆ Factbook: Bethany (Mount of Olives)

Temple BACKGROUND

Judas will throw the silver into the sanctuary (27:5).

◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

Court of Caiaphas (traditional) VIDEO

The leaders plot in the high priest's court (26:3); traditionally placed in the Upper City.

◆ Factbook: Caiaphas

08

Key terms

Messiah

VIDEO

'Anointed one': the anointed king (Greek Christos).

◆ Factbook: Messiah

Anointing

VIDEO

Pouring oil to set apart kings, priests and holy things; also a sign of joy.

◆ Factbook: Woman anoints Jesus at Bethany

Alabaster jar

BACKGROUND

A sealed stone flask for costly perfume.

◆ Factbook: Alabaster

Thirty pieces of silver

VIDEO

The price of a slave (Exodus 21:32) and Zechariah's insulting wage.

◆ Factbook: Thirty pieces of silver

Potter's Field

VIDEO

The field bought with Judas's silver, the Field of Blood (27:7-8).

◆ Factbook: Akeldama (Field of Blood)

09 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

ἀλάβαστρον

alabastron G211

Alabaster flask or jar.

Greek · Matt 26:7

◆ Factbook: Alabaster

μύρον

myron G3464

Perfume, fragrant ointment.

Greek · Matt 26:7, 12

ἐνταφιάζω

entaphiazō `G1779`

To prepare for burial.

Greek · Matt 26:12

δόλος

dolos `G1388`

Deceit, stealth, treachery.

Greek · Matt 26:4

ἀργύριον

argyrion `G694`

Silver; silver coins, money.

Greek · Matt 26:15

◆ Factbook: Thirty pieces of silver

καλός

kalos `G2570`

Good, beautiful, fitting.

Greek · Matt 26:10

מָשַׁח

mashach `H4886`

To anoint; root of mashiach, 'anointed one.'

Hebrew · Ps 45:7

◆ Factbook: Messiah

שָׂשׂוֹן

sason `H8342`

Joy, gladness, exultation.

Hebrew · Ps 45:7

מִשְׁחָה

mishchah `H4888`

Anointing, anointing oil. Look up: BDB, מִשְׁחָה.

Hebrew · Exod 30:25

שָׂכָר

sakar `H7939`

Wages, hire.

Hebrew · Zech 11:12

10

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

Perfume and burial

Costly perfumes were imported and kept sealed in alabaster flasks. Mark and John value this one at about three hundred denarii, roughly a year's wages (Mark 14:5; John 12:5). Bodies were anointed with spices for burial.

Bethany

A village on the far slope of the Mount of Olives, about two miles from Jerusalem, where Jesus stayed during Passover week (21:17).

Caiaphas

Joseph Caiaphas served as high priest about AD 18-36, the longest tenure of the period. An ossuary

inscribed 'Joseph son of Caiaphas' was found in Jerusalem in 1990.

SOURCED Early witnesses

> *For Jacob too anointed a pillar to God, and oil was offered in the sacrifices, and the priests were anointed with ointment.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 80, on 26:6-13. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

> *For saying, that it might have been sold for three hundred pence, they showed how much this woman had spent on the ointment, and how great generosity she had manifested.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 80, on 26:9. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

DEBATED Where scholars differ

One anointing or more?

Matthew, Mark and John describe an anointing at Bethany; Luke 7:36-50 tells of a sinful woman in Galilee. Most see Matthew, Mark and John as one event and Luke's as different.

Did Mary know?

The video asks whether she deliberately enacted Isaiah 61. Others think Jesus gave her act a meaning she may not have fully grasped. The video leaves it open.

Jeremiah or Zechariah?

Matthew 27:9 names Jeremiah. Explanations include a combined quotation (Zechariah 11 with Jeremiah 18-19 and 32) or citing the better-known prophet.

CAREFUL READING Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- John names the woman in John 12:3; John 12:7 is Jesus' reply.
- The 'oil' blessing in Deuteronomy 33 is verse 24 (Asher dipping his foot in oil); 33:4 is about the law.
- John says Judas objected; that he objected 'first' and the others followed is the video's inference.
- John places the anointing six days before the Passover (John 12:1); Matthew tells it after the 'two days' note (26:2) without dating it.

- That the perfume's scent lingered for days, reaching Pilate and the soldiers, is the video's imaginative picture, not stated in the text.

11 · BACKGROUND

From the anointing oil to Chrysostom

Coral dots mark what Matthew 26:3-16 echoes or this episode covers. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

C. 1446 BC DEBATED
Thirty shekels for a slave
Exodus 21:32 *Echoed: 26:15*

C. 1446 BC DEBATED
The holy anointing oil
Exodus 30:22-30

C. 1000 BC DEBATED
David anointed king
1 Samuel 16:13

C. 520 BC DEBATED
Zechariah's thirty shekels
Zechariah 11:12-13 *Echoed: 26:15; 27:3-10*

C. AD 30 DEBATED
Anointed at Bethany
Matthew 26:6-13 *This episode*

C. AD 30 DEBATED
Judas bargains with the chief priests
Matthew 26:14-16 *This episode*

C. AD 390
Chrysostom: priests anointed with ointment
Matthew 26:7

12

Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Luke 7:36-50
Another anointing, in Galilee
ADDED

1 Samuel 10:1
Samuel anoints Saul
ADDED

John 11:47-53
Caiaphas: one man should die for the people

Matthew 16:21
Jesus first foretells His death

ADDED

ADDED

Psalm 133:2

Oil on the head, on Aaron's beard

ADDED

13

Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1. Why did the disciples see waste where Jesus saw a good work?
2. What does anointing mean for kings, priests and holy things?
3. How do Exodus 21 and Zechariah 11 shape the meaning of thirty pieces of silver?
4. Where might a lack of mercy be keeping you from seeing what God is doing?
5. How can you let Jesus' response guide yours when you don't understand?
6. In what ways are you 'a fragrance of Christ' where you live?

14

Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson: lacking mercy leads to condemning what is not understood and becoming blind to the activity of God. The disciples looked with the wrong eyes; they should have let Jesus' reaction guide their response and shown the woman mercy even when they could not understand. The video asks: is there a disagreement, perhaps with a brother or sister over secondary theology, where a lack of mercy is keeping you from seeing God at work?

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

think of one person whose devotion you have criticized. Ask what Jesus might see in it, and offer them a word of mercy this week.

> *“Lacking mercy leads to condemning what is not understood and becoming blind to the activity of God.*
>
> From the video

15

Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ David ◆ Moses ◆ Isaiah ◆ Pharisees ◆ Galilee ◆ Righteousness
◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Jerusalem ◆ Book of Deuteronomy ◆ Book of Psalms ◆ John Chrysostom
◆ Disciples ◆ Gospel ◆ Healing ◆ Jeremiah (prophet) ◆ Lampstand ◆ Law of Moses ◆ Mercy
◆ Sanhedrin ◆ Solomon ◆ Tabernacle ◆ Valley of Hinnom ◆ Jacob (son of Isaac) ◆ Leprosy ◆ Paul
◆ Priest ◆ Compassion ◆ Judas Iscariot ◆ Messiah ◆ Mourning ◆ Sabbath ◆ Saul (king of Israel)
◆ Aaron ◆ Passover ◆ Denarius ◆ Annas ◆ Bethany (Mount of Olives) ◆ Elder ◆ Mount of Olives
◆ Alabaster ◆ Woman anoints Jesus at Bethany ◆ Caiaphas ◆ Akeldama (Field of Blood) ◆ Mary of Bethany
◆ Simon the leper ◆ Thirty pieces of silver

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Images: Wikimedia Commons (James Tissot, Brooklyn Museum; public domain). Map: drawn for this study.